

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 15

Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S)

CHAPTER II THE STRUCTURE OF SOCIETY • Groups Based on Kinship

CHAPTER II THE STRUCTURE OF SOCIETY

IN this and the following chapter I shall deal with the general organization of Tonga society as an essential background to the understanding of the family unit.

128
[Organization And Analysis Of Results](#)

The Administration has created a broader framework for Tonga society in terms of the Native Authority and the District Organization. The Tonga continue for the most part to relate themselves to one another through ties of kinship, locality, clientship, and formal friendships which stem from the past though the content of the relationships have changed in many respects.

128
[Organization And Analysis Of Results](#)

Groups Based on Kinship

Every Tonga is a member of some clan, and the clans are the most enduring units in the society. Though specific clan origin myths seem to be absent, the clans are thought to have come into existence with mankind and to have continued without change to the present day. In the north-western portion of the District, the clan system seems to resemble that of the Ila and the Sala. Throughout the rest of the District representatives of the same 12 to 14 clans are found. The clans are named, dispersed, exogamous units in which membership is derived through matrilineal descent. Each clan is linked or paired with several others individually in what is known as *bujwanyina*, a relationship of which joking is only one aspect of a wider range of duties and

171
[Comparative Evidence](#)

173
[Traditional History](#)

618
[Localized Kin Groups](#)

rights. But clans are not corporate bodies. They own no property, have no ritual centres or leaders, and never on any occasion assemble as a group. Furthermore, the tie of clanship does not create joint responsibility for one another's actions.¹

The corporate kinship groups are much smaller bodies of kinsmen which I refer to as 'matrilineal groups'. The Tonga word for such a group is *mukowa*. The same term is used for clan and has the wider meaning of species, kind, sort, or type. In some areas older people recognize the words *citiba* or *cilongo* as referring specifically to a matrilineal group, but in practice most apply these words also to the clan. Other words which seem to be used as synonyms for clan and matrilineal group are *cibuwa*, *mukwaasi*, *cikoto*, *cikombo*, *iciinga*, *luzubo*, and *cipani*. Specific kinship terms, however, are commonly used only within the matrilineal group, while fellow-clansmen are addressed by the generic term *mukwesu*, which Tonga translate as 'brother' though it would not be used between siblings.

601

Kinship Terminology

613

Lineages

¹ For a fuller discussion of clans, see Colson, 1953 *b*.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)